

Vello NeighborCard Design Fidelity Audit

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Friday Demo Deliverable

SUMMARY

What we did and why it matters

We asked Claude to generate a NeighborCard for Vello from scratch — the neighbor listing card from the Home screen. The first version looked reasonable, but when we checked it against the design system, we found token drift, data structure errors, and accessibility gaps.

The component has: real provider photo (not initials), verification mark (shield SVG), coral "Available" badge, bio, pricing with "from \$X / unit", distance with footprints icon in a pill, 5-star rating, and a navigation chevron.

Here we explain what went wrong, how we improved the rules, how the final component turned out, and what questions we still have.

THE MOST VALUABLE ARTIFACT

CLAUDE.md — The rules we give Claude so it doesnt drift

CLAUDE.md is basically an instructions file that Claude reads before generating anything. Its like telling it "these are the rules, dont skip them."

The first version was too simple: it listed 6 colors and said "dont invent." Claude followed the rules... technically. It used those colors, but since they were primitives and not semantic tokens, everything was connected to the wrong value.

What we learned: rules alone arent enough. You also need the full context. Rules without context = output that follows the letter but not the spirit.

Sources we loaded as context:

- Vello Design System (vello-design-system.vercel.app)
- Vello Product Brief (roles, flows, the local trust bet)
- Vello Prototype HTML (the real app classes and structure)
- Interview transcripts (6 from Kestrel Park, June 2026)

And this is how the guardrail improved with each failure:

Iteration 1 – Weak guardrail

We gave it 6 raw colors and said "dont invent." Claude used them, but since they were hex and not semantic tokens, everything was tied to the wrong value.

Iteration 2 – Semantic tokens + data contracts

Now we required semantic tokens: var(--surface-card)), not #FFF. Fixed the data structure and pricing to support the "from \$X / unit" pattern.

Iteration 3 – Accessibility + states

44px min on buttons, focus ring, prefers-reduced-motion. Card is <button>, not <div>. Verified mark uses native SVG, not Lucide icon.

Iteration 4 – Integration rules

After the floating overlay (felt outside the app), we added the rule: use Vello's native nb structure.

The guardrail ended up as a reusable document. The next component starts with better rules.

WHAT WENT WRONG IN CLAUDES OUTPUT

Errors we found reviewing the first version

1. Token drift — Looks similar but its not connected to the system

Claude used colors that visually matched Vello but put raw hex instead of design system tokens. The Available badge had hardcoded coral instead of var(--accent). The card background used #F6F2E7 (paper) instead of var(--surface-card). The verification mark used a Lucide icon instead of Vello's native shield SVG.

This happened in: card background, border, shadow, available badge, text colors, rating stars, and the distance pill.

2. Data contract — Claude assumed things that arent true

The first version passed rating as just a number (4.9) without stars. Vello's prototype uses 5 filled stars + the number. It also skipped the "available" state entirely.

Distance only supported "min walk" but the prototype has three formats: walk, blocks, and miles. Thats a data model change, not a UI change.

3. Accessibility — Works with mouse but not keyboard

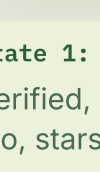
The card is a <button> in the prototype but Claude made it a <div> with onClick. That breaks keyboard nav. The chevron didnt have aria-hidden. The rating stars had no aria-label.

These are measurable rules (WCAG, ARIA). Engineering can check them before shipping.

THE FINAL COMPONENT

How it turned out after fixing the errors

This component didnt exist before — we generated it with Claude and corrected it. The final version uses semantic tokens, native shield SVG, structured data with three distance formats, and supports availability states.



Maya Rivera

Available

Dog walker & pet sitter, just up on 4th Ave.

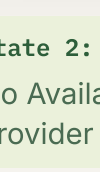
from **\$24** / walk

6 min walk

4.9

State 1: Available + featured

Verified, coral Available badge, photo, bio, stars, distance pill.



Devon Clarke

Handyman — shelves, leaky faucets, flat-pack furniture.

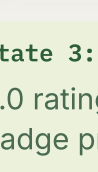
from **\$65** / flat

9 min walk

4.8

State 2: Not available

No Available badge. User knows provider exists but isnt free right now.



Priya Anand

Available

Deep cleans & move-outs. Eco supplies.

from **\$90** / visit

12 min walk

5.0

State 3: Perfect rating

5.0 rating, all stars filled. Available badge present.

AUDIT SUMMARY

What got fixed, specifically

Token drift (7 properties)	Accessibility (5 fixes)
Card surface	Root element
#F6F2E7 (paper) → var(--surface-card)	<div onClick> → <button type="button">
Available badge	Decorative chevron
hardcoded coral → var(--accent) with opacity	no aria → aria-hidden="true"
Verified mark	Accessible rating
Lucide ShieldCheck → native Vello shield SVG	no label → aria-label="Rated 4.9 out of 5"
Rating stars	Avatar photo
hardcoded amber → var(--rating)	 without alt → alt={neighbor.name}
Distance pill	Distance formats
div with gray border → pill with var(--border-default)	walk only → walk, blocks, mi as separate fields

QUESTIONS FOR THE DESIGNER

Things we couldnt resolve without asking

When we reviewed the component, there were values we couldnt trace to any token. Instead of guessing, we left them as open questions.

1. Does NeighborCard use --shadow-md, --shadow-brand (featured), or no shadow?

Why it matters: We used shadow-md for normal and shadow-brand for featured, but we couldnt find the official elevation in the design system.

2. Should the Available badge use var(--accent) with opacity, or is there a specific token?

Why it matters: We used coral at 10% opacity. If theres a semantic token like --surface-accent-tint, we should use that.

3. What happens when a neighbor isnt available — hide the card or show without badge?

Why it matters: Right now we show the card without the badge. The designer might want to gray it out or move it to the end.

4. The verified mark uses var(--brand-primary) for the shield. Is that right or is there a verification-specific token?

Why it matters: The prototype uses var(--green-600) directly. If verification color changes independently, it needs its own token.

WHAT ENGINEERING CONTRIBUTED

Not just implementing — catching when a UI decision is a system decision

- Found invisible drift: Claude used a Lucide icon for verification instead of Vello's native shield SVG.
- Turned the distance model from one format (walk) to three fields (walk, blocks, mi).
- Found that Claude skipped availability entirely. Without the badge, users cant tell if they can book now.
- Changed root from div to button — a tappable card must be a button for keyboard and screen readers.
- Discovered a component can render perfectly and still fail as product: the overlay was outside Vello's flow.

SOURCES AND PROCESS

Where each decision came from

This deliverable wasnt built in a vacuum. Every decision traces back to a concrete source:

Vello Design System

vello-design-system.vercel.app — Tokens de color (primitivos y semanticos), tipografia (Bricolage, Hanken, JetBrains Mono), escala de spacing 4px, radii, elevaciones, focus ring. Fuente para la tabla de tokens completa en CLAUDE.md.

Vello Product Brief

Define los tres roles (Requester, Provider, Community Admin), el scope hiperlocal, y la apuesta central: "trust scales locally." Fuente para las reglas de trust semantics y el contrato de datos en el guardrail.

Vello Prototype (HTML)

Archivo HTML descargable con el flujo completo: Home, request, booking, messages, profile, admin. Fuente para las clases nativas (section, neighbors, nb) y la referencia visual. La home screen es la referencia pulida; el resto tiene issues de UX plantados.

Discovery Interviews (6 transcripts)

Kestrel Park, junio 2026. Tres requesters, dos providers, un community admin. Evidencia para la separacion de trust signals (verificacion ≠ rating ≠ vouch) y para el pricing no-fijo.

Claude + CLAUDE.md (el guardrail)

Claude genero el componente inicial. CLAUDE.md actuo como el contrato del design system para Claude — tokens, trust, datos, a11y, integracion. Se itero 4 veces despues de fallos concretos.

Every correction traces back to one of these sources. Nothing was decided because "it looks fine."

Biggest lesson: the guardrail alone isnt enough. What actually improved the output was loading the design documentation as Claudes context. Rules without context = follows the letter but not the spirit. Context + rules = faithful output.

PROMPTS WE USED

What we asked Claude at each step

The prompts you use say a lot about whether you understand the problem. Here are the ones we used.

Step 1 – Generate the component

Context loaded: Vello design system, product brief, CLAUDE.md v1 (weak).

"Generate a NeighborCard for Vello using the design system tokens. The card shows: neighbor photo with verified mark, name, Available badge, bio, pricing with 'from \$X / unit', distance with footprints in a pill, 5-star rating, and a navigation chevron. Its a tappable button. Use React + Lucide icons. Follow CLAUDE.md rules."

Result: Rendered but with drift: raw hex, Lucide icon instead of native SVG shield, no availability, div instead of button.

Step 2 – Audit token by token

Context loaded: generated component, full design system, CLAUDE.md v2.

"Compare this NeighborCard property by property against the Vello Design System. For each visual value, tell me: what token it should use, what the component used, whether it matches or drifted, and the correction. Dont accept 'looks similar' – it has to be the exact token and native pattern."

Found 7 properties with drift. All corrected to semantic tokens.

Step 3 – Find product and accessibility errors

Context loaded: corrected component, CLAUDE.md v3 with a11y rules, product brief.

"Review this NeighborCard against WCAG: is the card a button or div? Tap targets min 44px? Chevron has aria-hidden? Stars have aria-label? Photo has alt text? Does Available badge rely on color alone? Is there prefers-reduced-motion?"

Found: div instead of button, chevron without aria-hidden, rating without aria-label. All fixed.

Step 4 – Integrate into Vello app

Context loaded: Vello prototype HTML, CLAUDE.md v4 with integration rules.

"Integrate the NeighborCard into the Vello HTML prototype using native classes: nb, nb_avatar, nb_vmark, nb_body, nb_top, nb_name, nb_avail, nb_bio, nb_price, nb_meta, nb_walk, nb_tap. It should look like another neighbor in the Trusted on your block list."

First: overlay (failed). Second: large section (dominated). Third: native nb structure, fit in.

Pattern: each prompt loaded more context. Guardrail updated after each failure. No magic prompt — just generate, review, fix rules, regenerate.